Chapter 7: Leave and Absence

7.1 Purpose and scope

This chapter explains how annual leave, sickness absence and special leave are managed across all branches. It applies to every employee on a permanent or fixed-term contract, including part-time staff.[1]

7.2 Annual leave

7.2.1 Entitlement

Your entitlement depends on your length of continuous service on 1 April each year.

Table 7.1 Annual leave for full-time staff

Years of continuous service	Basic entitlement (days)	Long-service days	Total (days)
Less than 2	25	0	25
2 to 5	25	2	27
6 to 10	25	4	29
More than 10	25	6	31

Part-time entitlement is calculated pro rata to contracted hours.

7.2.2 Booking leave

i. Submit requests through the rota system at least four weeks in advance.

ii. Your line manager will approve or decline the request within five working days, taking into account:

   (a) branch staffing levels during the requested period;

   (b) requests already approved for colleagues in the same team;

   (c) events that require extra cover, such as:

      - the summer reading challenge;
      - school holiday activity weeks;
      - annual stock-taking days.

iii. Requests for more than ten consecutive working days also need the approval of the Branch Manager.

Unused leave cannot normally be carried over to the next leave year.[2]

[1] Casual and agency workers are covered by the separate guidance in Chapter 12.

[2] Up to five days may be carried over into the first three months of the next leave year with written agreement.

7.3 Sickness absence

7.3.1 Reporting an absence

If you are too unwell to work, telephone your line manager before your shift starts. A text message or email is not an acceptable way of reporting sickness. When you call, you should:

1. give the reason for your absence and say how long you expect it to last;
2. tell your manager about any work that needs urgent attention, for example:
   a. reserved items waiting to be collected;
   b. room bookings you were due to supervise;
3. agree when you will next be in contact.

7.3.2 Fit notes

Self-certification covers the first seven calendar days of any absence. For longer absences you must provide a fit note from a doctor.[3]

When you return, your manager will hold a short return-to-work meeting with you. The meeting covers:

- how you are feeling and whether any adjustments to your duties are needed;
- any support available through the occupational health service;
- the dates of any further medical appointments.

7.3.3 Long-term absence

An absence of four weeks or more is treated as long-term absence. In these cases the Human Resources team will arrange a referral to occupational health and agree a plan for keeping in touch.

[3] Fit notes may be issued by a general practitioner, a hospital doctor or another authorised healthcare professional.

7.4 Special leave

Special leave is granted at the discretion of the Head of Service. It is intended for situations that annual leave cannot reasonably cover.

Table 7.2 Special leave

Reason	*Paid days per year*	*Approved by*
Bereavement (close family member)	Up to 5	Line manager
Moving house	1	Line manager
Jury service	Full period, less any allowance claimed	Head of Service
Emergency care of a dependant	Up to 3	Line manager
Public duties, for example as a school governor	Up to 6	Head of Service

Requests are made on Form HR-17 and should be submitted as early as circumstances allow.

7.5 Related documents

- Chapter 4: Working Time and Rotas
- Chapter 9: Health, Safety and Wellbeing
- Chapter 12: Casual and Agency Workers
- Form HR-17: Request for Special Leave

> **Who to contact**
> Questions about this chapter should be sent to the HR Advice Team. Your branch noticeboard lists the current telephone number and opening hours.